

UNSTOPPABLE BY DESIGN

Jasprit Bumrah writes **his own destiny**, and he does it in his own indomitable style.

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It's not a clever turn of phrase, nor is it a courteous gesture in a room full of journalists who have witnessed the highest highs and the lowest lows of the sport. You've rummaged through the back of your mind, rifled through options in Merriam-Webster, and still come up empty. You're just wide-eyed and wide-mouthed, letting out a simple "Holy s**t."

Bridgetown, Barbados — a verdant cricketing land that gave the world the three Ws (Frank Worrell, Everton Weekes, Clyde Walcott) and many other cricketing greats like Garfield Sobers — was suffering a shortage of superlatives as Jasprit Bumrah went about doing Bumrah things in the T20 World Cup final against South Africa on Saturday.

There is an air of invincibility around the 30-year-old pacer.

When Heinrich Klaasen was thrashing Axar Patel around in the 15th over, which eventually cost 24 runs and threatened to break India's defence of 176, Axar bowled two wide balls to avoid Klaasen's hitting arc. Bumrah, fielding at deep fine leg, realised what Axar was trying to do and walked back to his fielding mark with a sly smile, as if he could see the future.

At this point, South Africa needed 30 runs from 30 balls with six wickets in

hand, and questions were already being asked about Bumrah's late re-entry into the attack. But when he did come back in the 16th over, he conceded just four runs. "The 16th over, it was a run-a-ball, and we were up against it. But the ball was scuffed, and I knew I could get reverse swing. I am just happy that I kept calm and executed it," said the redoubtable Bumrah after the match.

He then returned for the 18th over, his last of the tournament. Klaasen was already back in the pavilion, but David Miller was still out there, with Marco Jansen for company, who is no muck with the bat. With six balls to do what he does best — making the opponent sweat, that is — **Bumrah not only clean-bowled Jansen with a perfect inswinger but also went for just two runs**, finishing the final with figures of 2 for 18.

He ended the competition with 15 wickets at an economy rate of 4.17 and an average of less than 8.26, rightly earning him the Player of the Tournament award.

Before the match, Bumrah was marking his run-up when he saw his wife, Sanjana Ganesan, a TV sports presenter. He put down the bucket of paint, and the couple hugged, with Sanjana wishing him good luck. Bumrah had earlier been to three finals and two semifinals across all formats in international cricket, but this time, as he walked away from his wife towards his teammates, he smiled at her with a thumbs-up, as if to say — "I got this."

And boy did he...Bumrah had seen the future. And in it, he was the king of the world!



MATCHES	WICKETS	ECONOMY
8	15	4.17